



PROJECT ASPIRE GHANA

A U.S.–Africa Partnership for TVET Transformation and Youth Workforce Empowerment

INVESTMENT CONCEPT NOTE

Prepared for Prospective Grant Partners & Impact Investors

March 2026 | Version 2.0

Hilltop Global Group

700 12th Street NW, Washington, DC 20005

Tel: +1 (202) 499-2284 | Fax: +1 (202) 350-9445

pagbeko@hilltopglobalgroup.com | www.hilltopglobalgroup.com

CONFIDENTIAL — NOT FOR REDISTRIBUTION WITHOUT WRITTEN AUTHORIZATION

Executive Summary

Africa's most valuable resource is not beneath the ground — it is in its classrooms. Project ASPIRE Ghana is designed to ensure those classrooms produce a workforce the continent's economy needs.

Project ASPIRE Ghana is a catalytic workforce development initiative designed to transform Ghana's Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) system into a high-performing engine for youth employment, entrepreneurship, and economic participation. The initiative directly addresses one of the most consequential development challenges on the African continent: the gap between the skills young people are taught and the skills employers and industries need.

Through a proven train-the-trainer model, Project ASPIRE deploys expert U.S. community college faculty to co-design curricula and deliver intensive workshops to Ghanaian TVET instructors across priority growth sectors, including renewable energy, construction technology, digital systems, agro-processing, advanced manufacturing, and more trade areas. Each trained instructor reaches hundreds of students annually, creating a multiplier effect that transforms the economics of workforce development from a per-student cost to a per-system investment.

The initiative is anchored in three institutional foundations that eliminate the typical risks of early-stage development programs:

- A signed Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) between Hilltop Global Group and the Ghana TVET Service (GTVETS), the national body responsible for all TVET delivery in Ghana, providing institutional access, policy alignment, and government endorsement.
- A formal facilitation agreement between Hilltop and the Community Colleges for International Development (CCID), a consortium of 90+ U.S. community colleges ensuring a deep and renewable pipeline of qualified technical faculty.
- Direct alignment with Ghana's 24-Hour Economy and Accelerated Export Development (24H+) Program and its ASPIRE24 sub-initiative, positioning the project within the Government of Ghana's highest-priority economic agenda.

Project ASPIRE Ghana is not a proposal seeking a framework. The partnerships are signed. Institutional access is secured. The national policy alignment is in place. What is needed now is the catalytic capital to move from agreement to execution.

The Opportunity: Why This, Why Now, Why Ghana

The Demographic Imperative

Africa is the youngest continent on earth, with a median age of 18. By 2030, the continent will add an estimated 375 million young people to its working-age population. Ghana, with a median age of 21 and a youth unemployment rate that significantly exceeds the national average, sits at the center of this demographic reality.

This is not a future challenge; it is a present one. The International Labor Organization estimates that sub-Saharan Africa needs to create 20 million new jobs annually just to absorb new labor market entrants. The gap between the skills young Africans are acquiring and the skills their economies need is widening, not closing.

The question is not whether Africa's youth will shape the global economy. The question is whether they will be equipped to do so or left behind by systems that failed to prepare them.

The Skills Mismatch

Ghana's employers consistently report difficulty finding job-ready technical talent. The World Bank's Enterprise Surveys for Ghana indicate that an inadequately educated workforce is among the top constraints to business growth. Meanwhile, graduates of TVET programs frequently lack the practical competencies, digital literacy, and industry exposure needed to secure productive employment.

The root cause is systemic: outdated curricula, under-resourced instructors, limited industry linkages, and a training model that has not kept pace with the demands of a rapidly modernizing economy. Addressing symptoms through one-off scholarships or short-term training programs has not worked. What is required is structural intervention at the instructor and institutional level.

The Policy Window

Ghana's 24-Hour Economy and Accelerated Export Development (24H+) Program represents the most ambitious economic transformation agenda the country has pursued in a generation. Its ASPIRE24 sub-initiative specifically targets skills development, industrialization, and productivity as national priorities. The Government of Ghana has publicly committed to TVET reform as a cornerstone of this agenda.

Project ASPIRE Ghana is designed to operate within this policy window, not adjacent to it. The MOU with GTVETS ensures that every intervention is aligned with national priorities, integrated into existing institutional structures, and positioned for government co-investment as the program scales.

The Model: How Project ASPIRE Works

Train-the-Trainer: A Multiplier Approach

Project ASPIRE does not directly train students. It trains the people who train them. This distinction underpins the program's scalability and cost-efficiency.

Expert U.S. community college faculty recruited through CCID's network of 90+ institutions are deployed to Ghana for intensive 10-day technical and pedagogical workshops at GTVETS centers. These workshops are co-designed with Ghanaian counterparts to ensure relevance, cultural fit, and institutional adoption.

The Multiplier Mathematics

Input	Output
10 U.S. faculty deployed	100+ GTVETS instructors trained in Year 1
100 trained instructors	5,000–10,000 students reached annually
Year 2–3 instructor cascade	25,000–50,000 students within 3 years
National institutionalization	Systemic TVET transformation across Ghana

This is not a linear investment. It is an exponential one. Every dollar invested in instructor capacity compounds through the system, reaching more students each year without proportional increases in cost.

Priority Growth Sectors

Curricula and workshops are designed around the sectors driving Ghana's economic transformation and aligned with the 24H+ Program's priority industries:

- Renewable Energy & Electrical Systems — Solar installation, power distribution, and smart grid fundamentals to support Ghana's energy transition.
- Construction Technology — Modern building techniques, safety standards, and project management for Ghana's infrastructure boom.
- Digital Technology & ICT — Networking, cybersecurity foundations, and digital tools for a technology-driven economy.
- Agro-Processing & Food Technology — Post-harvest handling, quality assurance, and mechanized processing for value addition in agriculture.
- Advanced Manufacturing — CNC machining, industrial maintenance, and quality control for the emerging manufacturing sector.

Program Activities

- Curriculum Co-Design: U.S. and Ghanaian faculty jointly develop and localize training modules aligned with industry standards and employer needs.
- Faculty Deployment: A minimum of 10 U.S. faculty delivers intensive workshops across GTVETS centers nationwide, with structured co-teaching alongside Ghanaian instructors.

- Industry Integration: Facilitated site visits, employer roundtables, and advisory partnerships ensure training remains connected to real labor market demand.
- Monitoring, Evaluation & Learning (MEL): Rigorous outcome tracking with baseline and endline assessments, instructor competency evaluations, and student employment tracking.

Theory of Change: From Investment to Impact

Project ASPIRE's theory of change is designed for investors who need to see a clear, traceable line from capital deployed to outcomes achieved.

Stage	What Happens	What It Produces
INPUTS	Catalytic funding, signed partnerships (MOU + CCID), U.S. faculty expertise, Hilltop project management	A fully resourced, institutionally embedded program with government endorsement
ACTIVITIES	Curriculum co-design, 10-day faculty workshops, industry linkages, MEL framework	Modernized training delivered on a scale through national TVET infrastructure
OUTPUTS	100+ instructors trained, updated curricula adopted, U.S. faculty professional development completed	A codified, replicable model for U.S.–Africa TVET collaboration
OUTCOMES	Higher-quality instruction, employable graduates, and durable institutional partnerships	5,000–10,000 students per year accessing industry-relevant training
IMPACT	Systemic TVET transformation, reduced youth underemployment, and inclusive economic growth	A scalable continental model for workforce development

The Partnership Consortium

Project ASPIRE Ghana is not built on aspirational partnerships; it is built on executed agreements. The institutional architecture is already in place.

Hilltop Global Group — Lead Implementer

Hilltop Global Group is a U.S.–Africa strategic advisory and education consulting firm headquartered in Washington, DC, with permanent operations in Accra, Ghana. Founded by Georgetown University Executive MBA alumni, Hilltop has over a decade of experience designing and delivering faculty-led programs, internships, and executive education across seven African nations in partnership with institutions including Georgetown University, NYU, Wake Forest University, UCONN, Fisk University, Kirkwood College, Emerson College, Imperial College London, and more institutions. Hilltop's CEO, Phil S. Agbeko, is a Fulbright Specialist and recognized thought leader in Africa-focused international education.

Ghana TVET Service (GTVETS) — National Host Partner

GTVETS is the Government of Ghana's designated agency responsible for managing all public TVET institutions across the country. The signed MOU between Hilltop and GTVETS provides institutional access to TVET centers nationwide, policy alignment with national reform priorities, and a framework for co-investment as the program scales. This is not a letter of intent; it is a binding agreement that positions Project ASPIRE within Ghana's official TVET infrastructure.

Community Colleges for International Development (CCID) — Technical Partner

CCID is a consortium of over 90 U.S. community and technical colleges committed to international education and workforce development. Hilltop's facilitation agreement with CCID provides access to a renewable pipeline of expert faculty across every priority trade area. Hilltop has also been designated by CCID as the lead organization for community college global workforce development programming in Africa, a distinction that reflects both institutional trust and operational capability.

Strategic Advisory Committee — To Be Constituted

A Knowledge Base of Experts and Advisory Committee composed of industry professionals, education specialists, development economists, and policy leaders will provide strategic mentorship, visibility, and guidance. This committee will inform resource mobilization strategy, support knowledge dissemination, and help position Project ASPIRE within the global workforce development ecosystem.

The Investment Case

Why This Investment Matters

Project ASPIRE Ghana offers funders a rare combination: a clearly defined problem, a proven model, signed institutional partnerships, government policy alignment, and a team with decades of experience in Africa. This is not a concept in search of validation; it is a validated concept in search of catalytic capital.

For Grant Funders

- Direct alignment with SDG 4 (Quality Education), SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth), and SDG 17 (Partnerships for the Goals).
- Measurable, attributable outcomes: instructor competency gains, student employment rates, curriculum adoption metrics.
- Government co-investment potential as the program demonstrates impact and scales within the national TVET system.
- A replicable model that can be adapted to other African countries, maximizing the return on philanthropic investment.

For Impact Investors

- An exponential multiplier model: investment in 10 faculty produces 100+ trained instructors reaching 5,000–10,000 students annually.
- Embedded scalability: the train-the-trainer approach reduces marginal cost per beneficiary as the program expands.
- Policy de-risking: the MOU with GTVETS and alignment with 24H+ ensure institutional sustainability beyond the funding period.
- Continental scale potential: successful execution in Ghana creates a proof of concept for replication across Africa's TVET ecosystems.

Seed Funding Request

We are seeking seed funding to execute the pilot phase of Project ASPIRE Ghana. The pilot will serve as proof of concept, validating the model, demonstrating measurable impact on instructor capacity and student outcomes, and building the evidence base for scale.

The pilot is designed to answer the only question that matters to a funder: Does this work? We are confident the evidence will speak for itself.

Detailed program budgets, timelines, and MEL frameworks will be tailored to funder-specific reporting requirements.

Pathway to Continental Scale

Ghana is the proving ground. The continent is the opportunity.

Project ASPIRE Ghana is deliberately designed as the first deployment of a model built for replication across the continent. Upon successful execution of the Ghana pilot, Hilltop Global Group will pursue a phased expansion strategy targeting African nations with established TVET ecosystems, demonstrated government commitment to skills development, and the institutional infrastructure to absorb and sustain a train-the-trainer model.

Why the Model Travels

The architecture of Project ASPIRE is portable by design. The train-the-trainer approach does not depend on permanent U.S. faculty presence; it builds local institutional capacity. The curriculum co-design process is inherently adaptive, shaped by each country's priority sectors and labor market realities. And the partnership model, which anchors implementation in a national TVET authority and draws faculty from a deep U.S. consortium, can be replicated wherever the institutional conditions are right.

Target Countries for Phase 2 Expansion

The following countries have been identified based on the strength of their TVET ecosystems, active national reform agendas, existing or emerging Hilltop relationships, and strategic alignment with the model's requirements:

Country	TVET Ecosystem Strength	Strategic Rationale
Rwanda	Rwanda TVET Board (RTB); national TVET policy aligned with Vision 2050; strong government digitization agenda	Continental leader in governance reform and technology adoption; ideal for digital skills and advanced manufacturing modules
Kenya	TVET Authority (TVETA); 200+ registered institutions; National Skills Development Policy	East Africa's largest economy, with a mature TVET infrastructure and strong private sector linkages
Senegal	Ministry of Employment and Vocational Training; national apprenticeship reforms; Francophone TVET model	Gateway to Francophone West Africa; successful deployment proves the model's adaptability across languages and systems
South Africa	TVET College system (50 public colleges); NDP 2030 skills targets; Sector Education and Training Authorities (SETAs)	The continent's most industrialized economy, with high youth unemployment and significant TVET reform investment
Ethiopia	Federal TVET Agency; 10-year development plan targeting industrialization; 1,300+ TVET institutions	Africa's second-largest population, with massive scale potential and a growing manufacturing sector

Morocco	Office of Vocational Training (OFPPT); industrial zones linked to the TVET pipeline	North Africa hub with automotive, aerospace, and renewable energy sectors demanding skilled technicians
----------------	---	---

Phased Expansion Timeline

- Phase 1 (Year 1–2): Ghana pilot execution, evidence collection, model documentation, and proof of concept validation.
- Phase 2 (Year 2–3): Expansion to 2–3 additional countries selected based on institutional readiness, government partnership potential, and funder alignment. Rwanda and Kenya are leading candidates for early expansion.
- Phase 3 (Year 3–5): Full continental program with a centralized operational hub, standardized curriculum framework with country-level adaptation, and a self-sustaining funding model blending philanthropic capital, government co-investment, and private sector partnerships.

The vision is to build a Pan-African TVET Excellence Network, a connected ecosystem of trained instructors, modernized curricula, and institutional partnerships that collectively raise the standard of technical education across the continent. Ghana is where it starts. The continent is where it leads.

Conclusion

Project ASPIRE Ghana represents a rare convergence: a clearly defined and urgent development challenge, a proven and scalable solution, institutional partnerships already in place, and a team with the credibility and operational capacity to deliver.

The partnerships are signed. The national policy alignment is secured. The faculty pipeline is established. The institutional access is confirmed. What remains is the catalytic capital to move from framework to execution and from execution to impact.

This is an investment in Ghana's next generation of workers, entrepreneurs, and economic leaders. It is an investment in a model that, once validated, can be replicated across the African continent. And it is an investment in the proposition that the most effective way to transform a workforce is to transform the people who teach it.

The infrastructure is built. The agreements are signed. The question is no longer whether this can work; it is who will be the first to invest in proving that it does.

Respectfully submitted,

**HILLTOP**
GLOBAL GROUP**Phil S. Agbeko**

Fulbright Specialist | Chief Executive Officer

Hilltop Global Group

700 12th Street NW, Washington, DC 20005

Tel: +1 (770) 744-0393 | Fax: +1 (770) 248-0754

pagbeko@hilltopglobalgroup.com | www.hilltopglobalgroup.com

Confidentiality & Legal Notice

CONFIDENTIAL — DO NOT DISTRIBUTE

This document and all information contained herein (the “Document”) is the exclusive property of Hilltop Global Group, LLC (“Hilltop”) and is provided solely for the purpose of evaluating a potential funding, investment, or partnership relationship with the intended recipient(s). This Document is strictly confidential and proprietary.

Unauthorized Reproduction and Distribution Prohibited. No part of this Document may be reproduced, copied, distributed, transmitted, displayed, published, or broadcast, in whole or in part, in any form or by any means, including but not limited to electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without the prior express written consent of Hilltop Global Group, LLC. Any unauthorized reproduction, redistribution, or disclosure of this Document, or any portion thereof, may constitute a violation of applicable intellectual property laws, trade secret protections, and contractual obligations, and may subject the violating party to legal action, including but not limited to claims for injunctive relief, compensatory damages, and recovery of legal fees and costs.

No Offer or Commitment. This Document does not constitute an offer, solicitation, or commitment to provide funding, enter into a contractual agreement, or engage in any business transaction. The information presented herein is for informational and evaluation purposes only and is subject to change without notice. Any investment, funding, or partnership arrangement arising from this Document shall be subject to the execution of definitive agreements containing mutually agreed-upon terms and conditions.

No Warranty or Representation. While Hilltop Global Group has made reasonable efforts to ensure the accuracy and completeness of the information contained in this Document, no representation or warranty, express or implied, is made as to the accuracy, reliability, completeness, or fitness for a particular purpose of any information, projection, estimate, or forward-looking statement contained herein. Recipients are advised to conduct their own independent due diligence and seek appropriate legal, financial, and professional counsel before making any investment or funding decisions based on this Document.

Forward-Looking Statements. This Document may contain forward-looking statements, projections, and estimates that are based on current expectations and assumptions. Such statements are inherently subject to risks, uncertainties, and changes in circumstances that may cause actual results to differ materially from those expressed or implied. Hilltop Global Group assumes no obligation to update or revise any forward-looking statements.

Governing Law. This confidentiality notice and any disputes arising from or related to the unauthorized use or disclosure of this Document shall be governed by and construed in accordance with the laws of the District of Columbia, United States of America, without regard to conflict of laws principles.

© 2026 Hilltop Global Group, LLC. All rights reserved.